checkin.com

Creator & Influencer Acquisition Strategy

A performance-paid creator program for Checkin.com, adapted from the Wispr Flow paid creator ad playbook (Lenny's Podcast, Hector Serrano).

Growth & Marketing · Internal

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0. A note on the source

I couldn't produce a verbatim transcript. The session's network policy blocks Apple Podcasts, the audio host and lennysnewsletter.com, so the audio couldn't be downloaded or transcribed. Lenny publishes the official transcript on the episode page: https://www.lennysnewsletter.com/p/how-a-19-year-old-intern-built-the

Part 1 comes from the episode's show notes, Lenny's post about it, and several secondary write-ups of Hector's talks and posts (sources at the end). Where those sources disagree, both figures are given. Before quoting any number externally, check it against the official transcript.

Part 1 — What the episode says (the Wispr Flow playbook)

Context

- Hector Serrano joined Wispr Flow (AI voice-to-text) at 19, days after leaving D1 soccer, before product-market fit. For about 1.5 years he made every ad himself.
- He then took a model e-commerce brands have used for years and applied it to software: **paid UGC (user-generated content) made by a roster of performance-paid creators**.
- Results as reported: about **50 creators** producing **500–600 (some sources say 500–700) new paid UGC ads per month**. Wispr Flow grew revenue about 30x in a year and raised at about a $2B valuation.

The mechanism, step by step

1. **Earn the right first.** Make the ads yourself until you know which angles, formats and audiences convert. Then hire creators to scale *volume and variety*.
2. **Start very small.** Begin with **4–5 hand-picked creators**. Each one fills a specific gap in the ad library: a new format, a new customer type or a new region.
3. **Scale in stages.** 5 → 10 → 20 → 40, settling at roughly 40–60 strong creators. Wispr went from 5 to 50 in about 4 months.
4. **Don't rely on inbound applications.** Of about 7,000 applicants, only about 5–7 were accepted. The better source is **outbound search**: search by keywords, then mine the followers, engagement and "similar accounts" of creators who already meet the quality bar.
5. **Pay on performance, with a floor.** - Creators earn **about 7% of the ad spend** behind their videos. If Meta keeps spending on an ad, the creator keeps earning; if it dies on day two, so does the pay. - New creators get a **guaranteed minimum** tied to volume (example: a $1,000 floor for 25 videos a month, topped up if commission falls short). - The episode compares **% of ad spend vs. % of GMV/revenue** as payout bases. - Top creators reportedly earn over $13k a month. - **$100 referral bonus** when a creator brings in another creator who meets the bar.
6. **Every video is a new idea.** Almost all output is new concepts and formats, not reshoots of a winner. Hector's view is that Meta groups near-duplicate creatives (around 60%+ similarity) and limits their reach, so variety beats iteration.

7. **Tight feedback loop.** A **weekly creator call** with the media buyer and Hector covers what's working, performance patterns, new customer segments and upcoming experiments.
8. **Invest in the roster as a community.** Top creators were reportedly flown to San Francisco for a week of product time, coaching and brainstorming.
9. **People over AI output.** Human creativity beats AI-generated ads, and "the best marketers are allergic to AI output".
10. **It works for technical and enterprise SaaS too.** The episode argues UGC isn't only for consumer products.
11. **Hire scrappy, young, ad-native marketers.** The person running this should live on the platforms.

Why the model works

- **Creative is the targeting.** On Meta, TikTok and LinkedIn the algorithm finds the audience; the advertiser's job is to supply many distinct, credible creatives.
- **Incentives line up.** Paying a share of spend means creators are only rewarded for ads the algorithm (and buyers) keep choosing.
- **Volume compounds learning.** 500+ distinct tests a month shows which angles, personas and objections matter far faster than an agency doing four concepts a quarter.

Part 2 — Translating it to Checkin.com

What's different about us

Wispr Flow	Checkin.com
Prosumer/SaaS, self-serve signup	B2B, sales-led: identity verification, KYC, onboarding and age verification for **iGaming, fintech, travel and telco**
Buyer = end user	Buyers = **Heads of Product/Growth/CRO, Compliance/MLRO, Fraud/Risk, CTOs** at operators
Conversion = trial → paid in days	Conversion = demo → POC → contract over weeks to months
Meta/TikTok main channels	**LinkedIn** first, then YouTube, podcasts, newsletters, and industry events (ICE, SiGMA, Money20/20, Web Summit)
Payout on ad spend works directly	Ad spend is still a usable base, but **pipeline** is the real outcome

Our structural advantage

Checkin.com sits in the most visible moment of the end-user journey: **signup and verification**. That's very demonstrable on video. "Watch me open an account in 25 seconds" and "this signup flow loses 40% of users, here's why" are native UGC formats. Conversion-rate teardowns are a popular creator genre on LinkedIn and X already. Our product shows up well on screen, which most B2B infrastructure doesn't.

The core idea

> **Build a "Checkin Creator Roster": 10–30 B2B creators paid mainly on the performance of their content when we put paid spend behind it (LinkedIn Thought Leader Ads / whitelisted posts), with a guaranteed floor plus a pipeline bonus. Combine it with a product-led "Onboarding Teardown" content engine that gives creators endless new ideas.**

Part 3 — Creator segments to recruit

Wispr picked creators to fill gaps in the ad library. We do the same, by **buyer persona × vertical × region**.

Segment	Who they are	What they make for us	Main buyer reached
A. Conversion/onboarding teardown creators	Growth and product creators who review signup flows and funnels (PLG, CRO, UX accounts)	"I tried to open an account at 10 betting sites / neobanks; here's who lost me", side-by-side flow comparisons	Head of Product/Growth/CRO
B. Compliance & RegTech voices	Ex-MLROs, AML consultants, KYC/AMLR/AMLA commentators, iGaming compliance lawyers	Explainers: "What the new EU AML rules mean for your onboarding", "UKGC affordability checks without killing conversion"	Compliance, MLRO, Legal
C. Fraud & identity creators	Fraud fighters, deepfake/AI-fraud researchers, ID security engineers	"Can a deepfake pass this KYC?", live injection-attack demos (with our liveness + Paravision partnership)	Fraud/Risk, CISO
D. iGaming industry insiders	Affiliates, operator ex-CMOs, iGaming podcasters and newsletter writers	Operator-level commentary, market-entry stories (e.g. new regulated markets in LatAm and the US)	iGaming C-level, product
E. Fintech/payments operators	Fintech founders and operators with LinkedIn audiences	"How we cut onboarding drop-off", build-vs-buy KYC takes	Fintech founders, CPOs
F. Travel & telco tech voices	Travel-tech and telco-digital commentators	Digital ID at airports, eSIM/SIM-registration KYC	Airline/telco digital leads
G. Regional/local-language creators	Same profiles in DE, ES/LatAm, Nordics, UK, Brazil, Africa, Middle East	Localized versions of the above	Local operators in new markets
H. Internal creators (employee advocacy)	Our own sales, solutions engineers, product people and founders	Behind-the-scenes, customer stories, "day in the life of a fraud analyst"	All

Start with segments **A, B and C**: they're the most visual, the most evergreen, and closest to buying intent.

Part 4 — The mechanism, end to end

Step 1 — Do it ourselves first (weeks 1–4)

As Hector did, **produce the first 20–30 pieces of content in-house** before recruiting anyone. - Record 10 "onboarding teardowns" of public signup flows in our verticals, showing time-to-verify, number of fields, drop-off risks, and how a Checkin.com flow compares. - Record 5 short fraud demos (deepfake/document fraud vs. liveness). - Run them as organic posts from 3–4 employee profiles, then as **LinkedIn Thought Leader Ads** with a small budget (€3–5k). - Output: a first map of **which hooks, formats and personas** produce clicks, demo requests and good-fit leads. That becomes the creator brief.

Step 2 — Find creators by outbound search (weeks 3–6)

Don't open an application form first. Wispr accepted about 0.1% of applicants. 1. **Keyword searches** on LinkedIn, X, YouTube and TikTok: "KYC", "AML", "onboarding UX", "conversion rate", "signup flow", "iGaming compliance", "deepfake fraud", "neobank review", in English and target languages. 2. **Network mining.** For every creator who meets the bar, check who engages with them, who they tag, and LinkedIn's "people also viewed". 3. **Sources specific to us:** speakers at ICE/SiGMA/Money20/20/RegTech events, guests on iGaming and fintech podcasts, Substack writers on fintech/regtech, our customers' own product people, and existing community members (G2 reviewers, partners). 4. **Quality bar (score 1–5 on each):** credibility with *our* buyer (not follower count), on-camera clarity, idea originality, consistency (posts at least weekly), audience fit (job titles of engagers), and no conflicts (not paid by a direct competitor). 5. Build a **long list of 150 → short list of 30 → first cohort of 5**.

Step 3 — Offer and contract (weeks 5–8)

Sample outreach DM (short and specific):

> "Hi {name}, loved your breakdown of {specific post}. We're Checkin.com: we build the signup and identity verification flows for {notable vertical customers}. We're starting a small paid creator program (5 people) where we put ad budget behind your content and pay you a share of that spend plus a monthly floor. You keep full creative control, and we give you access to our product, data and the teardown library. Open to a 20-minute call?"

Contract essentials - Exclusivity limited to the **identity verification/KYC category** only, for the contract term. - **Whitelisting/usage rights:** we can run their posts as Thought Leader Ads / Spark Ads / partnership ads for 6–12 months. - **Disclosure:** every piece is marked as a paid partnership (LinkedIn "Brand partnership" label, #ad, local rules such as the UK ASA/CMA, EU UCPD, Spain's influencer rules). - **Compliance review** (light, about 24 hours): factual product claims and regulatory statements only, not creative. - **Approved product claims list** (e.g. "certified by the KJM for German age verification"; avoid unverifiable conversion-uplift claims unless backed by a case study).

Step 4 — Compensation model (adapted for B2B)

Component	Wispr Flow	Checkin.com proposal
Performance share	~7% of ad spend behind the creator's videos	**10–15% of paid spend** behind their posts (LinkedIn CPMs are higher and volumes smaller, so a higher % keeps it attractive)
Guaranteed floor	e.g. $1,000 for 25 videos/month	**€1,000–2,500/month for 6–8 pieces** (B2B content is longer and more researched)
Outcome bonus	— (paid on spend)	**Pipeline bonus**: e.g. €250 per qualified demo attributed to their content, €1,000–2,000 per closed-won deal attributed (first-touch or influenced, via UTMs + "How did you hear about us?" field)
Referral	$100 per approved creator	**€250** per creator referred who joins the roster
Top-tier perks	Trip to SF	Join the Checkin.com stand/speaker slot at ICE/SiGMA/Money20/20, co-hosted webinars, early product access

Why add a pipeline bonus: in a long B2B sales cycle, paid spend alone doesn't show quality of reach. The bonus rewards creators whose audiences actually buy. Keep the bonus capped and the attribution rules written down, so they don't turn into arguments.

Step 5 — Brief and content engine

Wispr's rule: **every video is a new idea**. Our brief is a monthly **idea menu**, not a script.

Evergreen format library (start with 10): 1. *Onboarding teardown*: screen-record a real public signup flow and score it. 2. *Speedrun*: "Opening an account / verifying my age in under 30 seconds". 3. *Fraud attempt*: "I tried to fool KYC with an AI-generated ID / deepfake" (only on our own sandbox with synthetic test documents; never real stolen data, never attacking third parties). 4. *Regulation in 60 seconds*: new rules → what changes in the flow. 5. *Market-entry story*: "Launching in Brazil/Ontario/Germany: here's the KYC stack you need". 6. *Build vs. buy*: an engineer's honest view. 7. *Myth vs. fact*: "More KYC = lower conversion?" 8. *Customer voice*: a creator interviews a customer's product lead. 9. *Data drop*: creator reacts to a Checkin.com dataset (e.g. our yearly "State of Online Onboarding" benchmark; see Part 5). 10. *Persona POV*: "What a compliance officer actually thinks when your signup is slow."

What we give every creator: a sandbox account, a teardown checklist, a stats library, an approved claims sheet, customer-story access, and one 30-minute product session per month.

Step 6 — Paid distribution and the weekly loop

- **Channels:** LinkedIn Thought Leader Ads (main), YouTube Shorts/in-feed, Meta partnership ads for iGaming/fintech founder audiences where policy allows, X for fraud/security creators.
- **Targeting:** keep it fairly broad within the right job functions, company lists (ABM lists of target operators) and regions. Let the creative do the selecting.
- **Budget:** start at **€10–15k/month** in paid spend behind creator content. Shift spend toward winning *creators and formats*, not toward reposting the same winning video.

- **Weekly 30-minute creator call** (growth marketer + media buyer + one rotating person from product or sales): what worked last week, which objections sales is hearing, upcoming regulatory news, next experiments.
- **Monthly cull and refill:** drop the bottom 20% of creators by performance after a 2-month ramp, and add new creators who fill library gaps.

Step 7 — Scale in stages (Wispr's 5 → 50, adapted)

Phase	Creators	Pieces/month	Paid spend/month
Pilot (months 1–3)	5	30–40	€10–15k
Expand (months 4–6)	10–15	80–100	€25–40k
Scale (months 7–12)	20–30, across 5+ languages	150–250	€50k+ if CAC payback holds

For B2B, **20–30 good creators is the equivalent of Wispr's 50**. Don't chase their volume numbers. Gates between phases are listed in Part 6.

Part 5 — Our own ideas beyond the episode

1. **"Checkin Verified Creators" program.** Turn the roster into a visible brand: a public page, a badge, and a quarterly "Creator Summit" stream. That makes recruiting easier, much as Wispr's results made its program attractive.

2. **The State of Online Onboarding benchmark.** Use our platform data (aggregated and anonymized) plus manual teardowns to publish a quarterly benchmark: time-to-verify, fields required, and drop-off by vertical and country. Creators get first access and react to it. It gives everyone new ideas each quarter and builds our authority.

3. **B2B2C: creators for our customers.** Our operators (iGaming, fintech, travel) need consumer acquisition. Offer a **"Fast Onboarding" co-marketing kit**: consumer creators showing "I opened my account in 20 seconds" at our customer's brand, run as the *customer's* ads. Benefits: a stickier customer relationship, a proof point for new deals, and it shows our product in consumer UGC. This could become a paid add-on or partner network. *(iGaming consumer advertising is heavily regulated, so this is for fintech/travel/telco first and only licensed-market-compliant for gaming.)*

4. **Customer creators.** Many product, growth and fraud leads at customers want to build a personal brand. Offer them the same floor plus spend model to post about their onboarding wins. This gives us the most credible voice there is: the buyer's peer.

5. **Employee creator squad.** Make 5–8 employees (sales, solutions engineers, a fraud analyst, the CEO) part of the same system: the same brief, the same weekly call, Thought Leader Ads behind their posts, and a small monthly bonus for top performers. That costs almost nothing and reaches buyers with real credibility.

6. **Live red-team events.** A quarterly live stream where fraud creators try to beat our verification with deepfakes and synthetic IDs in our sandbox, together with Paravision. That's high-attention, newsworthy content, and it proves our product in public.

7. **Event creator crews.** At ICE, SiGMA and Money20/20, bring 3–4 roster creators as "the Checkin.com floor reporters" who do booth interviews, onboarding speedruns with visitors and session recaps. It turns trade-show spend into weeks of paid content.
8. **Podcast tour instead of a podcast.** Take Lenny's own tip, that guests should share the episode, in reverse: place our CEO and experts on 2–3 niche podcasts per month (iGaming, fintech, fraud) and cut every appearance into 5–10 short clips for paid distribution.
9. **AI-assisted, human-led.** In line with the episode's "people over AI output": use AI for research, transcripts, subtitles, translation and spotting formats that work, but never for synthetic presenters or fake testimonials. That matters even more for an identity-verification brand, whose whole positioning is *trust and real people*.
10. **Localization as the default.** We sell in many regulated markets. One English winner should get 3–5 *new* local versions made by native creators, not dubbed copies. That also avoids the near-duplicate penalty.

Part 6 — Measurement & KPIs

Leading (weekly) - New pieces published / per creator - Thumb-stop/hook rate (3-second view %), engagement rate among target job titles - CTR and cost per landing-page visit for Thought Leader Ads - Share of creatives that hit "winner" thresholds (e.g. top-quartile CTR)

Pipeline (monthly) - Demo requests and MQL→SQL from creator content (UTMs, unique landing pages per creator, a "How did you hear about us?" field, self-reported attribution in discovery calls) - **Cost per qualified demo** vs. other paid channels (target: at least 20% lower by month 6) - Influenced pipeline (opportunities where a contact engaged with creator content beforehand, using LinkedIn ad engagement and CRM matching)

Outcome (quarterly) - Creator-sourced/influenced closed-won ARR, and CAC payback - Branded search lift and direct traffic in target countries - Sales-cycle length for influenced vs. non-influenced deals

Phase gates - Pilot → Expand: at least 2 of 5 creators beat our in-house baseline on cost per qualified demo, and at least 10 SQLs attributed. - Expand → Scale: creator-influenced pipeline ≥ 3x total program cost (fees + spend).

Part 7 — Team, tools & budget

Team - **Creator Program Lead** (1 FTE): ad-native, hands-on, makes content too. As the episode says: scrappy, young, lives on the platforms. Wispr literally hires a "Content Creator Program Lead". - **Paid social / media buyer** (0.5 FTE, internal or freelance) focused on LinkedIn Thought Leader Ads. - **Support:** product marketing for claims and data, compliance (light 24-hour review), sales (weekly objection feed).

Tools - Discovery: LinkedIn Sales Navigator, Favikon / Modash / Creator.co (B2B creator search), manual X/YouTube search - Workflow and contracts: Notion or Airtable roster, DocuSign, payouts via a creator-payments tool (e.g. Trybe-type platforms as Wispr uses, or Tipalti/Deel) - Tracking: HubSpot (UTMs, self-reported attribution field, deal influence), LinkedIn Campaign Manager

Indicative pilot budget (3 months) | Item | Monthly | 3 months | |---|---|---| | Creator floors (5 × ~€1.5k) | €7.5k | €22.5k | | Performance share (~12% of spend) | €1.5k | €4.5k | | Pipeline bonuses (est.) | €2k | €6k | | Paid spend behind content | €12k | €36k | | Tools | €1k | €3k | | **Total** | **~€24k** | **~€72k** (excluding headcount) |

Part 8 — 90-day launch plan

Weeks	Actions
1–2	Hire/assign the program lead. Set up the claims sheet, sandbox accounts, UTM conventions and HubSpot attribution field. Pick 3 priority segments (A, B, C) and 2 verticals (iGaming + fintech).
2–4	Make 20–30 in-house pieces (teardowns, fraud demos, regulation explainers). Run €3–5k in Thought Leader Ads. Write down winning hooks and formats.
3–6	Outbound sourcing: long list of 150, short list of 30, 20 intro calls.
5–8	Sign 5 creators (one per segment/region gap). Onboarding session plus the first monthly idea menu. Launch the weekly creator call.
7–12	Creators publish 6–8 pieces each per month. Put paid spend behind the top 30%. Launch the employee creator squad. Publish the first onboarding benchmark.
12–13	Review against the phase gate: decide expand / adjust / stop. Plan the event creator crew for the next major trade show.

Part 9 — Risks & guardrails

- **Regulated verticals.** iGaming and financial promotion rules (UKGC, Spain's DGOJ, Germany's GGL, FCA financial promotions, the EU AMLR) apply to claims and targeting. Creators talk to **B2B buyers**, never promote gambling to consumers, and stay out of minors' feeds.
- **Disclosure.** Always label paid partnerships. Undisclosed endorsements are both illegal and a trust risk for an identity brand.
- **Fraud-demo ethics.** Use synthetic or test documents in our sandbox only. Never real personal data, never attack third-party systems, and don't publish step-by-step bypass instructions.
- **Data and privacy.** No customer data in content without written approval. Benchmarks must be aggregated and anonymized (GDPR).
- **Brand dilution.** The episode's own critique applies: big creator armies can hurt reach and brand. Keep the roster small and high-quality, and cull it monthly.
- **Attribution disputes.** Write bonus attribution rules into the contract, and cap bonuses.
- **Competitor overlap.** Category exclusivity for the contract term only.

Sources

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